

To do and for doing

Teaching guide

Explain a purpose or the function of an object.

Understand the distinction

Use to + base verb to explain an action's purpose: I went out to buy bread. Use for + noun for a purpose or recipient: a bag for groceries; a gift for Lee.

For + -ing often describes a function: a tool for opening bottles. A to-infinitive can also describe a use: something to open bottles with. Do not use for buying to explain why you went out in the basic I went out to buy pattern.

Compare the patterns

PURPOSE OF ACTION

I called to ask a question.

To ask gives the reason for calling.

FUNCTION

This brush is for cleaning shoes.

For cleaning describes the use.

RECIPIENT

This message is for Ana.

Ana is the intended recipient.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: I am saving money ___ buy a bike.

2. Complete: This tool is for ___ cans. (open)

3. Correct this: I went to the shop for buy milk.

Use it in your own life

Describe why you did something and the function of an object.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Use the infinitive to express the purpose of saving.

2. opening

A verb after for takes the -ing form.

3. I went to the shop to buy milk.

To buy explains the purpose of the trip.

One possible response

I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-29.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe why you did something and the function of an object.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.